evidence of panic. All those who had escaped, including the walking wounded, brought their weapons back with them—an indication of their good discipline and morale.' Collecting the third platoon that was deployed around Division HQ, the Garhwalis continued to act as a rearguard for the divisional retreat, arriving at Tawang on the evening of 23 October. By then Tawang had been evacuated, and the company commander, on his own initiative, decided to fall back on Jang via Sakden. They reached Jang on 28 October and married up with the rest of the battalion.

There are some serious questions about the tactics employed that unfortunately don't have any answers. On the night of 19 October, there was still the faint hope in Dalvi and Prasad that the Chinese were bluffing and that there would be no actual engagement between the two armies at Nam Ka Chu. Assam Rifles records are clear that the shelling of the region began at 4 a.m., and that the Chinese attack on No. 5 Platoon started at 4.30 a.m. It is almost certain that this information would have been relayed to Division HQ at Zimithang. Yet this vital information was not passed on to 7 Brigade who, almost forty-five minutes later, were under the first barrage of Chinese mortars and guns. Neither at this point nor subsequently, did the Chinese ever formally declare war.

The Chinese are reported to have severed the communication lines between 7 Brigade and 2 Rajput once the shelling started, but contact between Brigade HQ and Division HQ remained intact at least until 8.15 a.m., when the former was abandoned.

Communication is reported to have been in existence between 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers till noon. Yet, even when the Grenadier Company was attacked at the Drokung Samba Bridge, neither Division HQ nor the battalion thought it prudent to send reinforcements to the beleaguered men even though neither the position at Bridge 2 (9 Punjab) or at Bridge 1 (4 Grenadiers) had come under mortar or artillery fire. It is indeed strange that the only time Division HQ chose to speak to the commanding officers of these two battalions, they gave orders to withdraw, even though neither battalion had been engaged by the Chinese.

FLIGHT WITHOUT A FIGHT

The Indian political and military leadership at the highest level set the stage and the famed Red Eagles, 4 Division, played its part in offering up 7 Brigade to the Chinese as a passive target. True, both Niranjan Prasad and